

Prison Nurseries: A Way to Reduce Recidivism

The Prison Journal
2018, Vol. 98(6) 760–775
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DOI: 10.1177/0032885518812694
journals.sagepub.com/home/tpj



Joseph R. Carlson¹

Abstract

There have been eight U.S. states that have implemented prison nurseries in women's correctional facilities. This article examines the second oldest U.S. prison nursery program located in the Nebraska Correctional Center for Women. Using data from the program spanning the years 1994–2014, three main criteria were utilized as key performance indicators to evaluate success—recidivism within 3 years of initial offense, percentage of women returning to prison custody over the 20-year period, and program cost savings. Major findings related to women who participated in the nursery program include a 28% reduction in recidivism and a 39% reduction in women returning to prison custody. Overall, the program achieved cost savings of more than US\$6 million for the period 1994 to 2012.

Keywords

prison nursery programs, recidivism, cost savings

Introduction

Housing babies in prison is not a new phenomenon. Many Western European, Asian, and South American countries allow women to keep their newborn infants with them in prison. According to the United Nations, in 1987, out of

¹University of Nebraska at Kearney, USA

Corresponding Author:

Joseph R. Carlson, Department of Criminal Justice, University of Nebraska at Kearney,
Founders Hall, 905 West 25th Street, Kearney, NE 68849, USA.
Email: carlsonj@unk.edu

the 70 nations researched, the United States was one of only four countries that routinely separated incarcerated mothers from their newborn babies (Ghose, 2002). The United States is one of a few larger countries that routinely separates incarcerated mothers from their newborn infants (Caddle, 1998; Quaker United Nations Office, 2005). This was not always the case. Up through the 1950s, many U.S. states had previously allowed newborns to remain with their incarcerated mothers. Craig (2009) provides a more complete and detailed history of mother and child prison programs in England and the United States, noting the theories of rehabilitation that supported them and the obstacles they faced. In the United States, costs and lack of need, along with the fact that most infants could be placed with family members, were cited as reasons for prison nursery closures (Kauffman, 2001). However, since the 1950s, the traditional U.S. solution has been to either divert pregnant offender mothers away from confinement or to have those that are incarcerated give up the care of the child to relatives, foster care, or adoption at birth (Pollock-Byrne, 1990).

In contrast, Herzog-Evans (2013) reports that in France, babies are normally allowed to remain with their incarcerated mothers for 18 months. Yet, there is still an ongoing debate as to how long these babies should be allowed to remain with their mothers in prison and under what conditions (Martin, Lau, & Salmon, 2013). Research in Canada has led to recommendations that mothers and infants be housed together with 24-hr contact because it is essential for establishing and maintaining breastfeeding on demand. They also report on the long-term negative effects of foster care placement regarding developing babies and young children (Martin et al., 2013).

In general, U.S. women inmates who give birth in prison are separated from their infants within a few days after birth. The prison nurseries in place today are designed for nonviolent and short-term inmates who will give birth while incarcerated, but will generally be released within 18 to 36 months or less after the birth (Carlson, 1998, 2009). Women who have longer prison sentences or histories of child abuse are ineligible to participate in prison nursery programs. A study by Grubb and del Carmen (2016) recommends basic procedures for the counseling and medical treatment of all pregnant women in custody, regardless of whether they are in a nursery program or not. They indicate that many state statutes and administrative regulations are inadequate for meeting the needs of pregnant inmates, both during pregnancy and the postpartum period, according to the guidelines provided by the National Commission on Correctional Health Care (NCCHC) and the American Public Health Association (APHA). Two states that appear to have the most comprehensive coverage for the treatment of pregnant inmates are California and Pennsylvania (Grubb & del Carmen,

2016). Women in nursery programs are usually required to participate in parenting courses, take care of their own child, and refrain from disruptive behavior that would result in misconduct reports. In some cases, women are required to take classes to complete their general educational degree (GED) or to work part-time within the institution both before and after the baby is born (Carlson, 2009).

Although the overall goals of each state nursery program may differ, most have similar objectives. A woman is usually considered a successful program participant if she is able to remain in the program and leave the institution with her baby (Carlson, 2009). The number of women incarcerated in the United States has increased by more than 700% since 1980, growing from a 1980 population of 26,378 to 213,722 in 2016 (Carson, 2018). Furthermore, it is estimated that 6% to 10% of women are pregnant at intake (Pregnancy in Prison Statistics, 2016).

Contemporary Prison Nursery Programs and Research Studies

As of January 2016, eight states (Illinois, Indiana, Nebraska, New York, Ohio, Washington, and West Virginia) had operational prison nursery programs that allowed incarcerated mothers to keep their babies for 12 to 36 months. South Dakota allows the child to remain 30 days (Campbell & Carlson, 2012; Carlson, 2001; Radosh, 2002; Stern, 2004; Villanueva, From, & Lemer, 2009; Yager, 2015). Wyoming's nursery program in their Lusk Wyoming Women's facility has been approved by their state legislature and facilities built, however they have not yet implemented a full program due to lack of correctional staff.

The Nebraska Correctional Center for Women (NCCW) is Nebraska's only female inmate confinement facility. NCCW has a combination of maximum, medium, and minimum custody inmates, opening in 1920 with a design capacity of 139 inmates (Carlson, 1998; also see Table 1). The prison nursery has the capacity to house 15 women and their babies. Nebraska, like other states, has had a dramatic increase in incarcerated women, from 64 in 1982 to 194 in November of 1999 (Carlson, 2001). As of June 2017, NCCW, with a capacity of 275 beds, had an average of 345 prisoners (ACLU-Nebraska, 2017).

In 1994, Nebraska's Department of Correctional Services was awarded a grant from the National Institute of Corrections to supplement Nebraska State funds in establishing a nursery program (Carlson, 1998). In November 1994, the prison nursery program was established in the NCCW, designed to meet the needs of women inmates serving short sentences who gave birth during their confinement (Clarke, 1993, Yager, 2015).

Table 1. The Nebraska Correctional Center for Women at York, Nebraska (Nebraska Department of Correctional Services, 2014).

Capacity was 319 inmates or 116% as of August 31, 2015
17 buildings on 27 acres
Average inmate population of 328.08
Average cost per inmate US\$39,875
Average staff: 126.5
Custody levels: Maximum, medium, minimum
American Correctional Association accredited since 1981
Average age: 33.75 of 394 inmates
73.9% were first time offenders
Average minimum sentence was 30.89 months, the maximum sentence was 60.25 months
Race
White: 65.2%
Black: 16.5%
Hispanic: 9.4%
Native American: 6.6%
Drugs: 38.5%, theft: 20.8%, fraud: 9.0%, burglary: 3.9%
Three-year recidivism rate (FY 2012) all women: 24.3% out of 350 women

New York State has the longest running prison nursery program, in operation since 1902 (Carlson, 2009). Located in the State Correctional Institution at Bedford Hills, the nursery is run entirely by the State Department of Correctional Services. In a 3-year study released in 1997 (New York State Department of Correctional Services [NYDOCS], 1999), compared with all women released by the State of New York Department of Correctional Services, prison nursery participants had a lower recidivism rate for the 3 years following release. For the first year after release, 5% of the nursery program's participants returned to custody, compared with 8% of nonparticipating inmates. After the second year, it was 7% versus 19%; in the third year, it was 13% versus 26% (New York State Department of Correctional Services [NYDOCS], 1993, 1999).

The Washington Corrections Center for Women nursery program located in Gig Harbor, Washington, was established in 1999. Initial results indicate that of the approximately 50 women who have been released from the nursery program, only five (about 10%) have returned to the prison on new charges (Ghose, 2002).

Data attributing reductions in inmate recidivism related to participation in prison nursery program participants are scarce. In support of documenting reduced recidivism, Whiteacre, Fritz, and Owen (2013) examined the Indiana

Women's Prison Wee Ones Nursery (WON) program. Comparing recidivism rates of women ($n = 90$) participating in the prison nursery who gave birth while in prison with women who would likely have been eligible ($n = 98$), they found WON participants had a slightly lower rate of new arrests within 1 year of release (26% vs. 31%). They also conducted follow-up qualitative interviews with a sample of WON participants ($n = 15$) and pre-WON inmates ($n = 12$). WON participants had a significantly lower rate of new admissions to the Department of Corrections within 1 year of release compared with the pre-WON control group (10% vs. 18%). Importantly, they found that 86% of the WON group still had legal custody of the child born in prison. This is compared with only 58% of the control group who had to give up their newborn and were thus deprived of the bonding process. Their overall conclusions were that WON was achieving its stated goals (Whiteacre et al., 2013).

The arguments in favor of mother-child bonding and attachment related to prison nursery programs are too numerous for the scope of this article. However, several prison nursery studies are worthy of noting. For example, babies who resided in the New York State prison nursery and whose mothers received additional developmentally supportive nursing intervention showed motor and mental development within normal limits during the nursery stay (Byrne, Goshin, & Joestl, 2010). Furthermore, rates of secure attachment were not significantly different from those seen in low-risk community groups of children (Byrne et al., 2010). In another study, children who spent time with their mothers in a prison nursery had significantly lower mean anxious/depressed and withdrawn behavior scores than children who were separated from their mothers in infancy because of incarceration (Goshin, Byrne, & Blanchard-Lewis, 2012).

Cassidy et al. (2010), in a study of pregnant women jail inmates in Baltimore, Maryland, documented that it is possible for pregnant women with a history of substance abuse in a jail-diversion program to rear infants who are securely attached to them. Their findings suggest that future interventions hold promise for improving the outcomes of mothers and their infants involved in the criminal justice system. Outcomes of participants in Tamar's Children, a 15-month jail-diversion intervention for pregnant, non-violent offenders with a history of substance abuse were favorable. Twenty women and their infants completed the full treatment (a residential-living phase from pregnancy until infant reached the age of 6 months, and community-living phase until the age of 12 months), with extensive wrap-around social services. Their results were that (a) program infants had rates of attachment security and attachment disorganization comparable with rates typically found in low-risk samples (and more favorable than those typically found in high-risk samples), (b) program mothers had levels of maternal sensitivity

comparable with mothers in an existing community comparison group, and (c) improvement over time emerged for maternal depressive symptomatology, but not other aspects of maternal functioning.

Countering these studies are arguments that women in confinement are not suitable for healthy parent–child attachment or bonding. They premise that even if the mother does bond with the child, she will shortly return to custody after release on a new offense and have to leave the child behind. Thus, the bonding process should be facilitated for someone other than the mother, such as a grandparent or foster parents. Another argument is that when the incarcerated mother leaves prison and regains custody of her child, she disrupts the initial attachments that have been formed.

So, for example, Johnson (1993) noted that 11% of those children separated from their incarcerated mothers had experienced at least two changes in caregivers during the period of the mother's incarceration. One may consider if there is constant change of caregivers, that bonding may not be occurring. Other opponents have argued that the prison is an unsafe environment for infants or that they may be in danger from other inmates who may have child abuse offense histories. However, at NCCW and most other prisons, the babies and their mothers are separated from the general prison population. There have been no cases of such child abuse documented in the 20 years of the Nebraska program (personal communication with Mary Alley, Parenting Program Coordinator, February 2, 2016).

From the legal community, one of the critics, James Dwyer (2014), a professor in the William and Mary School of Law, has criticized prison nurseries for not having the best interests of the child in mind and possibly exacerbating problems. He views prison nurseries as a violation of the Fourteenth Amendment, incarcerating infants who have not been found guilty of a crime. He further adds that there is no empirical evidence to show that the mother–infant prison programs actually improve the outcomes of children.

Similarly, Carol Strickman (2015), an attorney at Legal Services for Prisoners with Children (LSPC) and who represents mothers in prison, opines that prisons are prisons first and nurseries second. “Prison systems shouldn’t run these programs,” she says. “Mother–infant programs should be focused on the children and parenting.” The LSPC report further concludes that women may be reluctant to complain for fear of being ejected from the program.

In contrast to the above arguments, Kanaboshi, Anderson, and Sira (2017) argue that “babies, not mothers, have a constitutional right to remain with their mothers while they are in prison.” This is based on the documented ill effects on children who are removed from their mothers and do not have the opportunity to bond and form attachments with them.

Even with the negative debates on the appropriateness of prison nursery programs, the establishment of the nursery program in Nebraska received positive local and national media attention. Beginning in 1995, the Governor's wife identified this program as one of the most beneficial state programs. She personally made the plaque presentation for the "Good Beginnings" award at the facility, thus giving positive recognition to the nursery program. Numerous articles have been written on the program in the *Omaha World Herald*, *Lincoln Journal Star*, the *York News-Times*, *People Magazine* 1996, *Child's View* 1996, *Life Magazine* 1997, *Jubilee: The Magazine of Prison Fellowship Ministries* 1999, *Corrections Today* 1999, and *USA Today* 1999 (Carlson, 2001). Also, there was a positive 2007 HDNET World Report TV documentary on the NCCW Nursery Program (Carlson, 2009).

Method

Procedure

This study was conducted with the cooperation of the Nebraska Department of Correctional Services and staff of the NCCW. General data for NCCW are provided in Table 1. Prison nursery data which included confinement and release dates, types of offenses, basic demographics, and whether the released woman returned to custody were provided by NCCW staff.

At NCCW, prior to the implementation of the live-in nursery program that was in place from January 1991 until October 1994, 30 women inmates had babies and were forced to give them up (control group). An analysis of women in the control group indicates they would have qualified for the current NCCW nursery program. Other comparisons support that the control group and experimental group were similar in age, length of sentence, and their primary offense involved drugs. This is one of the few studies where a comparison is made between a control group of women inmates who had to give up their infants at birth and women inmates who were allowed to keep their babies with them once the new nursery program started. Most other state comparisons studies have been based on women inmates in their nursery program compared with women in the general prison population.

All pregnant women inmates at NCCW who volunteered and were eligible for the nursery program were included in this study, and there was no experimentally manipulation. The purpose of the research was to determine whether the NCCW Nursery Program had been effective in reducing recidivism among pregnant women inmates who have successfully completed the nursery program within the last 18 years, compared with those who had to relinquish custody of their infants before the program began. Clearly, support of

this research question could result in documenting measureable cost savings to the state accruing from reduced recidivism and foster care costs. So, a related research focus was determining whether such cost savings occurred. Data for this investigation came from the examination of confinement and release dates, along with the recidivism data from program records. This information was provided by NCCW's administrative staff, and the results were further reviewed by the NCCW Parenting Program Coordinator for accuracy.

It is important to note a limitation to this study. This involves the commitment of new offenses in another state by a former Nebraska incarcerated. For example, if a woman inmate is released from confinement in Nebraska and commits an offense for which she is institutionalized in another state within 3 years, she is labeled a "first term offender," not a recidivist. This is a common problem for all states because of the lack of shared reporting systems across different state correctional departments. For this study, a recidivist is defined as one released to the community and then recommitted for a new crime or for a technical violation within 3 years of prison release (Nebraska Department of Correctional Services, 2014). For a more comprehensive picture, this research will use the term *returned to custody* to indicate that the prior released inmate has returned to correctional custody after the 3-year "recidivist" time period.

Participants

Participants were all pregnant women inmates at NCCW who gave birth while incarcerated during the years 1991 through 2014. The database consisted of historical data provided by correctional staff at the Nebraska Correctional Center (NCCW) in York, Nebraska, over a period of 23 years.

Eligibility requirements for the NCCW nursery program originally stated that applicants for the Nebraska nursery program must meet basic eligibility criteria: (a) the applicant must have a tentative release date of no more than 18 months after the birth of the child (this has been changed recently to no more than 24 months) and cannot be in segregated status; (b) mothers must not have an extensive history of violence and prior convictions of child abuse; and (c) the mother must sign a program agreement stating she will be the primary caregiver of the child upon release; she must also complete prenatal and Lamaze classes if possible. To remain in the program, the mother must abide by the institution's rules, avoid misconduct reports, and complete specified infant care and child development classes. While having responsibility for the care of her child, each mother has a half-time morning work assignment until the baby is 6 months of age. At that time, she may apply for a

Table 2. Demographics of Pregnant Women Inmates Giving Up Their Babies Compared With Those in the Nursery Program Keeping Them.

	Group 1, <i>n</i> = 30 (1991-1994— gave up baby)	Group 2, <i>n</i> = 65 (1994-2004)	Group 3, <i>n</i> = 85 (2004-2014)
Nursery program	No	Yes	Yes
Average age	25	25	27
Race			
White	47%	76%	61%
Black	50%	12%	8%
Hispanic	3%	7%	8%
Native American	0%	5%	11%
Offenses			
Drugs	42%	51%	42%
Bad checks/forgery	19%	27%	14%
Theft/burglary	19%	12%	25%
Assault	4%	2%	12%
Other	16%	8%	7%

full-time assignment. A participant who has not graduated from high school is required to participate in GED classes half time, and the nursery the other half. Withdrawal from the nursery program may be involuntary or voluntary (Carlson, 1998). These basic eligibility requirements are still in effect.

Three comparisons groups of women inmates are presented in Table 2. Specific demographics for those women inmates who had to relinquish custody from 1991 to 1994 are represented in Group 1. Inmates who successfully completed the nursery program from 1994 to 2004 are represented in Group 2, and those inmates who successfully completed the program from 2004 to 2014 are in Group 3.

Table 3 summarizes the comparison between successful program participants for the first 10-year period and the following 10-year period. Specific demographic data on women inmates from 1994 to 2004 are shown in Table 4. These results were obtained from voluntary and anonymous surveys from the NCCW nursery women participants (Carlson, 1998, 2001, 2009). The survey was not administered to women inmates from 2005 through 2014.

Results

From the implementation of the live-in nursery program, November 1994 until December 2012, there were 142 women who successfully completed the

Table 3. Nursery Program Successful Inmates, First 10 Years and Second 10 Years.

Group 2 (1994-2004)	Group 3 (2004-2014)
<i>n</i> = 65 inmates	<i>n</i> = 82 inmates Total over 20 years: 147
Marital status: Unknown	67% single
Average no. of children: 2.68	1.63
Average stay of babies in months 2.86 months (1994-1999); 6.8 months (1999-2004)	7.78 months (2004-2009)
Groups 2 and 3 combined (1994-2014)	
0% have tested positive for drugs while in the nursery program	
0% no new offenses or law suits for child abuse while in the nursery program	

Table 4. Demographics of Pregnant Women Inmates (*n* = 65) in the Nursery Program 1994-2004 (Carlson, 2009).

19.5% indicated this was their first baby
2.86 children before incarceration
7% breast fed baby
77% of women inmates indicated they had been on public assistance before entering
59% indicated that their mother had been incarcerated
95% of the women indicated they felt a stronger bond/attachment to their new baby and recommend the nursery program
10% of the fathers visited babies on weekends
13% had reduced misconduct reports after entering the program (1994-1996)
Average stay for babies for first 5 years was 2.86 months (1994-1999)
Average stay for babies for the next 5 years was 6.8 months (1999-2004)

program and left with their children (experimental group). These women inmates were allowed to keep their babies in prison with them up to either 18 or 24 months. In 2013 and 2014, another five women successfully completed the program and left with their infants (they were not counted because there has not been a lapse of 3 years since their release; however, none have returned as of May 2016). Recidivism and return-to-custody data past the 3-year mark were calculated for the control group and experimental group (see Table 5).

Results indicate a 28% reduction of recidivism among nursery program participants as well as a 39% total reduction in the numbers of participants' returning to custody over an 18-year period (53% – 14% = 39%). The recidivism rate statistical analysis is significant at the 5% level.

Table 5. Recidivism Comparison of Women Who Gave Up Babies Compared With Those Who Successfully Completed the NCCW Nursery Program.

Total women	Returned within 3 years	Returned after 3 years	Total returned within 18 years
C = 30	12 or 40%	4 or 13%	16 or 53%
E = 142	17 or 12%	3 or 2%	20 or 14%

Note. NCCW = Nebraska Correctional Center for Women; C = control group of 30 women who had babies and were forced to give them up (January 1991-October 1994); E = experimental group of 142 women inmates who successfully completed the nursery program (November 1994-December 2012).

Table 6. Recidivism Rates for Pregnant Women Who Gave Birth in Prison at NCCW (1990-2012).

	Returned to prison	Did not return to prison
Allowed to keep baby	17 (23.94)	125 (118.06)
Baby was taken away	12 (5.06)	18 (24.94)

Degrees of freedom = 1

$\alpha = .05$

$\chi^2_0 = 3.841$

H_0 = The variables were recidivism rates for pregnant women who gave birth in prison and whether the baby was allowed to stay with them in prison or be taken away are independent variables.

H_a = The variables recidivism rates for pregnant women who gave birth in prison and whether the baby was allowed to stay with them in prison or be taken away are dependent variables.

Observed (O)	Expected (E)	$\frac{(O - E)^2}{E}$
17	23.94	2.012
125	118.06	0.408
12	5.06	9.518
18	24.94	1.931
		$\chi^2 = 13.869$

Reject the null hypothesis

Note. NCCW = Nebraska Correctional Center for Women.

Cost Savings by Utilizing a Prison Nursery

Savings from reduced recidivism. Based on the figures in Table 6, if there had not been a nursery program at NCCW, then, hypothetically, 53% of the 142

women inmates, or 75 women, would have returned to custody, as demonstrated by the control group's return rate. The 2014 Annual Report for NCCW indicates the cost to the state of Nebraska to incarcerate one woman inmate per year is US\$39,875 (or US\$3,323 per month). The average minimum sentence at NCCW is 30.89 months, and the average maximum sentence is 60.25 months.

If each of these 75 women had returned to custody with an average minimum sentence of 30.89 months, this would be equal to 2,317 months. The potential cost savings would be US\$7,699,391 (2,317 months $\times$ US\$3,323 per month/inmate) over the past 18 years to Nebraska taxpayers (in 2014 dollars).

Foster Care Savings

For those babies of incarcerated mothers who could not be placed with family members, the state placed them in foster care. These foster care expenses, then, become an economic drain on the state. The last national study, which is dated, reported this happening in about 10% of cases nationwide (Snell & Morton, 1994).

For Nebraska, minimum foster care rates (July 1, 2014) for infants, age 0 to 5 years, are US\$620 per month or US\$20 per day (<http://www.childrens.nebraska.gov/PDFs/MeetingDocuments/2014/FCRate/April1/NFCFCRateReport04012014.pdf>), with rates rising depending on special needs of the child. Nationally, approximately 10% of incarcerated women who have to give up their babies while they remain incarcerated do so through foster care (Snell & Morton, 1994).

From November 1994 to 2014, 147 women successfully went through the NCCW Nursery Program. If the 147 women had lost custody of their children, then it could be theoretically expected that 10% (the national average) or 15 babies would have gone into state foster care, and their costs passed on to taxpayers. Assuming the baby would be in foster care for 18 months (length of time they were allowed to remain with their mothers at NCCW after birth), the cost savings would have been

US\$167,400 = 15 babies $\times$ 18 months each $\times$ US\$620/month for foster care—a direct cost savings due to the NCCW Nursery Program.

In the interest of accuracy, there was a cost to the taxpayers to establish and operate the NCCW Nursery Program that should be deducted from the overall cost savings. In 1994, the cost to establish the program was determined to be US\$29,800; however, Nebraska received an initial grant of US\$24,800 from the National Institute of Corrections in 1993 and the Nebraska State Legislature provided the other US\$5,000 (Carlson, 1998).

Table 7. Total Cost Savings Over 18 Years.

US\$719,424	=	US\$39,968/per year operating budget (FY 2012) × 18 years.
US\$583,344	=	US\$32,408 yearly salary (FY 2014) for the nursery program coordinator × 18 years.
+US\$5,000	=	US\$29,800 to establish program minus US\$24,800 grant.
US\$1,307,768		
US\$7,866,791	=	Cost savings in avoided recidivism and foster care costs
–US\$1,307,768	=	Costs to establish and operate nursery program
US\$6,559,023	=	Total cost savings to the state over 18 years

The NCCW's operating budget for FY 2012 was US\$39,968. It is estimated that the yearly salary of the nursery program coordinator was US\$32,408 per year. These costs were multiplied by 18 years and deducted from the cost savings from recidivism and foster care costs to yield a total cost savings of US\$6,559,023 (see Table 7).

Discussion

The most important findings over this 20-year retrospective study of the NCCW Nursery Program were the reduction of recidivism rates over a 3-year period and the total reduction in return to custody over the 18-year period for women who successfully completed the NCCW Nursery Program. Based on statistical analysis, there is evidence to conclude that the recidivism rate reduction was significant. In sum, women inmates who successfully completed the NCCW Nursery Program were less likely to come back into the prison system within 3 years, thus reducing the recidivism rate from 40% for the control group versus 12% for the experimental group. In addition, the total women returned to custody after 3 years (definition of recidivism) was also reduced from 53% of the control group returning versus 14% of the experimental group returning. Over the 18-year time frame and due to the utilization of the prison nursery program, there was a 28% reduction of recidivism (returning to custody within 3 years) and an overall 39% total reduction of women returning to custody.

Based on the 142 women who were successful NCCW graduates of the nursery program over 18 years, had there not been a nursery program, then 53% of those 142 inmates—hypothetically 75 women—would have returned to custody and 10% of their babies would have gone to foster care. Therefore, it can reasonably be assumed that by implementing the NCCW Nursery Program in 1994, there was an estimated US\$6,559,023 in total cost savings over 18 years to Nebraska taxpayers through the reduction of recidivism and foster care costs.

As mass incarceration has continued to bring women offenders into U.S. state and federal correctional systems at higher rates than male offenders, the issue of how to deal with pregnant inmates and their newborn infants remains critical. Currently, most states remove the infants from their incarcerated mothers; however, the findings of this and other studies suggest that a better alternative is the establishment of prison nursery programs. In response to possible taxpayer and politician queries on the cost savings of such a program, the current study has demonstrated both reduced recidivism and foster care costs over time. Correctional officials and policy makers should be made aware of such cost savings program models and consider the implementation of prison nursery programs in their states. Most importantly, the evidence that a nursery program promotes mother-child "bonding and attachment during incarceration and upon reentry" is worthy of consideration for its role in interrupting the cycle of incarceration.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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Author Biography

Joseph R. Carlson is a professor at the Department of Criminal Justice at the University of Nebraska at Kearney. His primary research and publication focus is on women's correctional issues. Other research on "Correctional Officer Burnout " was published in *The Prison Journal*.